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## 1. First Week's Agenda

### 1.1 Day 1

- Course Outline/Procedures, Overview of Objectives
- Introductions
- Brief overview of Canvas
- Study tips
- Question and answer

### 1.2 Day 2

- Introduction to the topic of government: What is Government? What is Politics?
- Activities/Discussion: Experiences with Government
- Question and Answer

### 1.3 Due Dates Begin Immediately

This Week (Module 0 - avoid non-participation drop August 30)

- REQUIRED Syllabus Quiz Due August 30
- REQUIRED Extra Credit Quiz Due August 30 11:59 PM
- No extensions - you will be dropped on August 31 if not complete

## 1.4 Module 1 Dates

### Module 1 - Quiz September 21

- Module 1 Study Guide Due September 18, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 1 E-book Assignments due September 18, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 1 Quiz - In Class, September 21, beginning of class

- Module 2 Head Start Day - September 23, no class

## 1.5 Module 2 dates

- September 23 - Head Start Day - no class
- Quiz October 12

- Study Guide Due October 9, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 2 E-Book Assignments October 9, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 2 Quiz - in Class, October 12, beginning of class

- October 14 - Module 3 Head Start Day - no class

## 1.6 Module 3 dates

- October 13 - Module 3 Head Start Day - no class
- Quiz November 9

- Study Guide Due November 6, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 3 E-Book Assignments Due November 6, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 3 Quiz - in class, November 9, beginning of class

- November 11 - Module 4 Head Start Day - no class

## 1.7 Module 4 dates

- November 11 - Module 4 Head Start Day - no class
- Quiz November 30

- Study Guide Due November 28, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 4 E-Book Assignments Due November 28, 11:59 PM in Canvas
- Module 4 Quiz - in class, November 30, beginning of class

- Final Exam December 2 in class, regular time, regular classroom

## 1.8 Introduction

- Welcome to GOVT2305: Federal Government
- Instructor: Tom Hanna, MA
  - Office Hours: Wednesday or Thursday 2 to 4 PM, will vary by week, online
  - Email: tom.hanna@hccs.edu
  - Office: University of Houston, Phillip Guthrie Hoffman Hall (PGH 391) during fall/spring semesters

## 1.9 About me:

- Ph.D. candidate in Political Science at the University of Houston
- MA in Political Science from the University of Houston, BS in Political Science from the University of Houston
- I have been teaching at the University of Houston since July 2022, at Houston Community College since June 2023, and taught in 2024 at Our Lady of the Lake University - San Antonio (online).
- Courses taught: At UH - Statistics for Political Scientists; Argument, Data, and Politics; Introduction to Comparative Politics; International Organizations; US and Texas Constitution and Politics; US Government: Congress, the Presidency, and the Courts. At HCC - Federal Government and Texas Government. At OLLU - State Government (Comparative).
- Research: My research focuses on the international behavior of dictators. I have a specific interest in threats to freedom and modern liberal democracy (aka Madisonian republics). I use quantitative methods including advanced machine learning methods and, tentatively, quantum computing.
- Not (just) an Ivory Tower intellectual - former business manager and owner.
- Interests: cooking, camping, kayaking, and computer gaming

## 1.10 Lecture vs Textbook

- The lecture is not a substitute for the textbook
- The textbook is not a substitute for the lecture
- Neither is a substitute for assigned readings (or viewings/listenings)
- The textbook provides a description of institutions and concepts in the American system
- The lecture will focus on why these things matter
- The assigned readings give background, expand the opportunity for critical thinking, and provide common ground for discussion

## 1.11 Lecture Overview

- What is government and what is politics?

- Ethics of and in government
- What are the ethical consequences of the nature of government? Why do we need to limit government in a democracy/why limit majorities?
- Why do we need to limit government? Why should a democracy be limited?
- How do we limit government in a democracy? In the US system in particular?

## 1.12 Lecture Overview

- What are the dangers of disinformation, misinformation, and statistics?
- What is the good and bad of factual information presented by the press? By activists? By politicians?
- How can we be fully informed and why should we?
- What is the citizen's (your) role in government? What is ethical voting? Is it ethical not to vote? Is it ever unethical to vote?

## 1.13 Major course expectations

- I do not expect you to be experts on the course material at the end
- I do expect you to:
  - Respect other people, starting with your classmates and myself
  - Do the work
  - Do your best
  - Take responsibility for the work you did or not do
  - Take some time to seriously consider the implications of the material for your own life and the lives of people you care about
  - Come to class prepared

## 1.14 Come to class prepared

- To earn full credit for In Class Work (25% of your grade), you must come to class prepared
- Part of this means at least reviewing the assigned readings
- Sometimes this will mean coming in with some written notes as assigned
- Good discussion - no quizzes, full credit
- Bad discussion - quizzes to find out who was prepared

## 1.15 Course Outline/Procedures

- Begin Module 0 immediately
- Please read the Canvas Homepage for the Course
- Please read the Syllabus
- Most of your work outside class will be done through the Canvas Modules - this includes accessing the textbook

- Complete numbered Modules (0 through 4) in order or you will be locked out of later assignments
- Always work through the Modules

### 1.16 Syllabus Quiz and Extra Credit Quiz

- The Syllabus Quiz is required
- The Extra Credit Quiz is extra credit AND it is required
- Introduction Module complete by August 30, 11:59 PM
- This includes textbook signup
- No extensions - you will be dropped for non-participation early August 31 if you do not complete it

### 1.17 Course Policies: Basics

- Number 1 Rule: Respect for other people

### 1.18 Course Policies: Basics

- Number 1 Rule: Respect for other people
- The policies exist to help me help you succeed
- I may update policies if things are not working
- **You are responsible** for keeping track of due dates and assignments

### 1.19 Time Commitment

- HCC is accredited by SACSCOC
- Without accreditation an HCC degree is worthless
- Without accreditation HCC students no financial aid
- - According to SACSCOC:

- 1 credit hour = 1 hour in class + 2 hours out of class per week
- This is a 3 credit hour course
- 3 credit hour class = 3 hours in class + 6 hours out of class per week for a face-to-face class
- 9 hours per week, 135 hours total

<https://sacscoc.org/app/uploads/2019/08/Credit-Hours.pdf>

### 1.20 Commitment

If 67% of the work is outside of class, what does that tell you about who has the major responsibility for your success or failure?

## 1.21 Professionalism

- Professionalism is a graded component of this class.
- A major hallmark of professionalism is taking responsibility for doing what is expected of you and not blaming others for the consequences if you do not.

## 1.22 Professionalism in other words

- If you don't attend class and pay attention...
- If you don't put in six hours a week of real work outside class...
- If you don't do the assignments...
- If you don't study for the quizzes...

Who is responsible for the consequences?

## 1.23 Your responsibilities

- Time management
- Your own learning
- Doing the assignments (or accepting the zero)
- Doing the assignments on time (or accepting the consequences)
- Showing up and engaging
- Applying brainpower
- Working on the material
- Following through on commitments
- Asking for help
- Taking responsibility for your own work and results!

## 1.24 My responsibilities

- Providing you a structured environment to learn
- Providing alternate explanations to help you understand the material (lecture, discussion, and question-answer)
- Setting standards and goals
- Challenging you to do your best
- Holding you accountable
- Providing you with resources to succeed
- Assessing you fairly based on the standards and goals provided
- Alerting you early if your work is not up to standard, so you can fix the problem
- Offering suggestions to help you improve your work (when asked)

## 1.25 NOT my responsibilities

- Forcing you to work
- Doing your work for you
- Navigating the HCC bureaucracy for you
- Anything your other professors require of you that may interfere with this class
- Giving credit for work that is not submitted - I will not
- Granting extensions, makeups, or other exceptions to the syllabus - I will not
- Negotiating excuses - I will not
- Negotiating grades - I will not

## 1.26 Course Procedures - Communication

- Announcements will appear in class and in Canvas Announcements
- If class is cancelled, I will post this in Canvas Announcements and send to your official college email

### My Eagle

- This is the only way we will use email or Canvas Messaging in this class

## 1.27 Email and Work-Life Balance

I honor and respect boundaries around personal time, well-being, family, and care-taking. Should you receive emails from me while you're doing these things, please protect your time and wait to respond until you are working. In the same vein, please note that I check and respond to email **very** unreliably during evenings, weekends, and academic breaks.

- Our main means of communication will be Face-to-Face during scheduled class time or during scheduled office hours.

## 1.28 Email absolutes

- No discussion of grades by email
- No excuses by email
- Do not email me to tell me you have missed or will miss class
- Do not email asking for special treatment, special extra credit, or a grade "round up"
- Any email not from your official email address will not even receive a courtesy reply

## 1.29 Office Hours

- I will hold office hours on Google Meets



- For those who would rather meet in person, most of my office hours will be at my physical office at University of Houston, PGH 391
- I will post links to Google Meets and my Office Hours Schedule on the Course Homepage, along with a map to my office building

### 1.30 Course Policies: Communications

- Face-to-face is the best communication
- Announcements: In class and recorded in Canvas
- Class cancellation: Email and Canvas
- There will be no need to email me because...

### 1.31 Late Work and Makeups

- Late textbook assignments are automatically accepted and one is dropped

- 5% per day penalty
- No exceptions, no excuses!!!
- No need to email!!!
- No need to apologize or explain!!!
- All work must be turned in by December 2

### 1.32 Late Work and Makeups (2)

- Late work is automatically accepted with penalty
- Makeups for quizzes

- The final is your makeup for any missed exams
- You will get the percentage score for the final applied to any missed quiz
- The final is a makeup, not a do-over
- No excuses, no exceptions
- This is completely automatic
- No emails or apologies required
- Let your grandmothers know their lives are safe from this class!

### 1.33 Late Work and Makeups (3)

- Late work is automatically accepted with penalty
- Makeups for exams - the final is the makeup, automatic
- Makeup for in class work participation exercises, etc.

- By not missing more than three days, you will be able to receive full points.

- Missing more than three days is not excusable in any case and may technically result in being dropped from the course.
- No makeups, no exceptions for any reason.

### 1.34 No excuses, no exceptions

- **The policy is generous and automatic**
- **The policy is very generous policy - No exceptions**
- **Asking for special treatment is asking me to do something unethical and will affect your professionalism grade**

### 1.35 Study Guides

- These out of class written assignments will not be accepted late
- You may miss one out of four Study Guides
- For the first missed Study Guide, you will receive the average of all other Study Guide scores
- If you miss two, the zero for the second WILL be part of the average

3

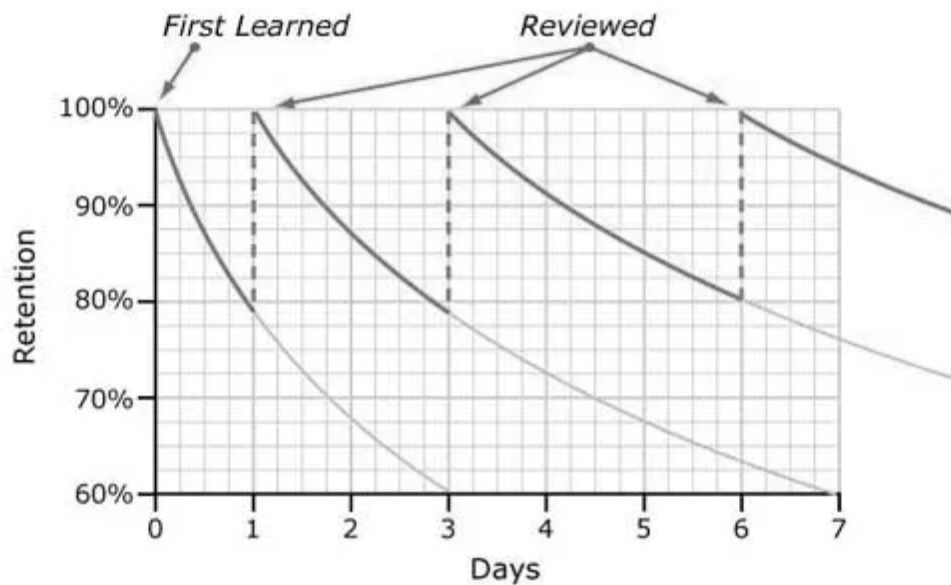
### 1.36 Course Policies: Attendance and Participation

- HCC requires attendance
- There will be almost daily exercises involving discussion, writing, or a combination
- These will only be done in class
- I will drop the three lowest scores including missed classes
- No other makeups will be allowed

### 1.37 Course Policies: Academic Integrity

- Academic integrity is non-negotiable
- Do your own work
- Academic integrity includes basic integrity
- Bullying, extortion, etc. violate academic integrity, behavior policies, and in some cases the law
- #1 Rule: Respect other people

## 1.38 Study suggestions: The forgetting curve



### *The Forgetting Curve*

## 1.39 Conquer the Forgetting Curve

- Study a few minutes a few times a week instead of 6 hours right before the test
- Start the Connect Assignments early (see Syllabus for suggestions)
  - You have several weeks to do each set of 3 to 6 chapter assignments
  - Finish them ahead of schedule then use them to study by...
  - Revisiting the Connect Assignments several times between finishing them and the exam to review
- Use the Flashcards a few minutes, a few times a week

## 1.40 Use a good notetaking system

- Use the lecture slides to organize your notes
  - Please do not take pictures of the slides - they are published in Canvas with a PDF download option available
- Try rewriting concepts in your own words
  - If you don't understand something, use the index in the book to find more
  - Use a reputable dictionary such as <https://www.merriam-webster.com/>

or [https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/us/definition/american\\_english/](https://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/us/definition/american_english/) to look up words you don't understand

- Come to office hours and ask
- Ask in class

## 1.41 Use a good notetaking system

- Use a good notetaking system such as [Cornell Notes](#)
- Make a study guide: Making a study guide yourself (using a system like Cornell Notes) is much more effective than staring at a study guide prepared for you
- Take advantage of the Practice Quizzes *after you do these other things*

## 1.42 Extra Credit

You can get extra credit equal to 10% of each quiz by turning in a Cornell Notes style set of notes on the chapters, assigned readings, and lectures for the full Module. This would be at minimum two pages per chapter, reading, and lecture. Turn these in on paper at the beginning of each Quiz.

## 1.43 Next class

- Come prepared to discuss the questions:
  - How has government affected my life recently?
  - When I think of government, what do I think of?
  - Why is politics important in my life?
- Bring any questions over course procedures, the assignments, Canvas, textbook, etc. to ask in person

## 1.44 Questions

## 1.45 Authorship and License

- Author: Tom Hanna
- Website: [tomhanna.me](http://tomhanna.me)
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